

The Whale and

CHAPTER 1 : TECHNOLOGIES AS FORMS OF LIFE

The Reator

THE ABSENCE OF A PHILOSOPHY OF TECHNOLOGY

- “The philosophy of technology is that there really isn’t one.”
- “The six-volume *Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, a recent compendium of major themes in various traditions of philosophical discourse, contains no entry under the category “technology.”
- “Engineers have shown little interest in filling this void.”

pp. 16-17 / 194



Technological Somnambulism

Somnambulism: sleepwalking

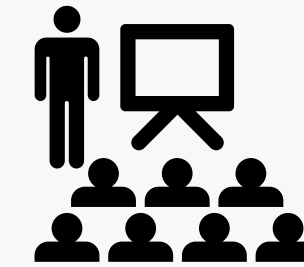
“The language of the notion of “use” also includes standard terms that enable us to interpret technologies in a range of moral contexts. Tools can be “used well or poorly” and for “good or bad purposes”



Faith in Progress:

Innovations consistently seen as a path to salvation.

“It is still a prerequisite that the person running for public office swear his or her unflinching confidence in a positive link between technical development and human well-being and affirm that the next wave of innovations will surely be our salvation.” P.17/194



Conventional View of “Making” and “Using”:

Society conventionally divides concerns about technology into the groups of makers and users. *“The deceptively reasonable notion that we have inherited from much earlier and less complicated times divides the range of possible concerns about technology into two basic categories: making and use.” P.18/194*

Technologies as Reshapers of Life:

Technologies are not merely aids but powerful forces that reshape human activity and its meaning:

“If the experience of modern society shows us anything, however, it is that technologies are not merely aids to human activity, but also powerful forces acting to reshape that activity and its meaning.” p.18

Practices and Perspectives:

Winner uses the example of a robot in a workplace, which not only boosts productivity but also redefines "work" itself. Similarly, new medical techniques transform not just what doctors do, but how people perceive health and sickness

Structures: The legal system, too, must "stretch and reorient its traditional categories" to address new phenomena like "computer crimes" and the concept of intangible "electronic information" as property

Terms and Definitions: The anecdote of a student whose paper "crashed" illustrates how technological mishaps introduce new "forms of activity" and "moral negotiations" into daily life, creating new rules and expectations (e.g., regarding excuses for late work)

Worlds' collision: The example of a pedestrian and a driver attempting to communicate highlights how technology (the car) creates distinct "worlds" with incompatible operating conditions, subtly yet powerfully restructuring "individual habits, perceptions, concepts of self, ideas of space and time, social relationships, and moral and political boundaries"

Beyond Impacts and Side Effects

But an unfortunate shortcoming of technology assessment is that it tends to see technological change as a “cause” and everything that follows as an “effect” or “impact.” - p. 21

● Winner criticizes traditional “*technology assessment*” for viewing technological change primarily in terms of “**cause**” and “**effect**” or “**impacts**”. This approach often **assumes changes are inevitable**, with humans simply needing to adapt.

Instead, he proposes recognizing that “**as technologies are being built and put to use, significant alterations in patterns of human activity and human institutions are already taking place. New worlds are being made**”

It begins with the recognition that as technologies are being built and put to use, significant alterations in patterns of human activity and human institutions are already taking place. - p. 22

Forms of Life

- Winner explicitly draws on Ludwig Wittgenstein's concept of "forms of life" to explain how devices, techniques, and systems become "woven into the texture of everyday existence" and "shed their tool-like qualities to become part of our very humanity".

Witgenstein argued that “the speaking of language is a part of an activity, or of a form of life.” P.22

- He also refers to Karl Marx's concept of "production" as a "definite mode of life," where by changing material things, we change ourselves, actively creating and recreating the world we live in. This perspective helps understand how technology not only changes what we do but who we are

“By changing the shape of material things, Marx observes, we also change ourselves.” P.25

Forms of Life

- *Witgenstein points to a vast multiplicity of cultural practices that comprise our common world. Asking us to notice “what we say when,” his approach can help us recognize **the way language reflects the content of technical practice.**” and “If Witgenstein is correct, we would expect that changes of this kind would appear, sooner or later, in the language people use to talk about themselves. Indeed, it has now become commonplace to hear people say “I need to access your data.” “I’m not programed for that.” “We must improve our interface.” “The mind is the best computer we have.”*
- *Marx, on the other hand, recommends that we see the actions and interactions of everyday life within an enormous tapestry of historical developments. But on the whole his theory seeks to explain very large patterns, especially **relationships between diferent social classes**, that unfold at each stage in the history of material production. These developments set the stage for people’s **ability to survive and express themselves, for their ways of being human.***

Return to Making: A Call for Deliberate Choice

- *however, is not to suggest that either one or both provide a sufficient basis for a critical philosophy of technology. Proposing an attitude in which forms of life must be accepted as “the given,” Wittgenstein decides that philosophy “leaves everything as it is.”... If one hopes to interpret technological phenomena in a way that suggests positive judgments and actions, Wittgensteinian philosophy leaves much to be desired. most Marxists have believed that while capitalism is a target to be attacked, technological expansion is entirely good in itself, something to be encouraged without reservation. **In its own way, then, Marxist theory upholds an attitude as nearly lethargic as the Wittgensteinian decision to “leave everything as it is.”***
- *As we “make things work,” **what kind of world are we making?***
- *Are we going to design and build circumstances that enlarge possibilities for growth in human freedom, sociability, intelligence, creativity, and self-government? Or are we headed in an altogether different direction?*
- *It is true that not every technological innovation embodies choices of great significance.*
- *Much more than we have acknowledged in the past, **we must admit our responsibility for what we are making.***